FASHION
PERSONALITY

There are many remarkable things about Giorgio Armani. One is that at 90 years of age he is still working hard, overseeing all aspects of his large fashion empire. Another, perhaps even more astonishing, is that he still owns 100 per cent of the business he founded almost 50 years ago. In today's fashion landscape, which is dominated by corporate conglomerates like LVMH, Kering and Richemont, who between them own many of the world's luxury fashion brands, this independence speaks of commendable single-mindedness. And, finally, his menswear is never really out of fashion.

This is because the Italian designer is no longer simply in the fashion business. The name Armani has joined an exclusive list that includes Rolex and Rolls-Royce, where brands have transcended product categories to become symbolic of a certain attitude and status.

Armani man is all about minimalism, elegance and connoisseurship. He is a global citizen whose preference for timeless style over passing fads marks him out as a knowledgeable adult. Just as when you think of Ferrari you think of red-blooded (and red-coloured), sexy Italian design, so Armani symbolises an alternative Italy—one of confident and relaxed style, linear and textured interiors, and dark or neutral-coloured tailoring worn for aperitivos. And the famous figures who grace the red carpet in his tuxedos.



"I do not deal in passing trends," the designer says. We meet backstage before the big show he staged last week in New York. In uncharacteristic black tie—his trademark outfit is a navy blue long-sleeved knit, navy blue trousers, white trainers and (very Armani) round sunglasses—he looks the picture of elegance. "I seek the timeless, the elegant. Trends go out of style, that is their nature. But elegance does not date."

This elegance was on show in New York this month, where Giorgio Armani came to town after an 11-year absence to open his new project at 760 Madison Avenue, like a returning emperor. This undertaking speaks volumes about what the boy who was born in Piacenza in 1934 has achieved. Housing not only his women's and men's collections, but also accessories, his interiors collection (Armani/Casa), a forthcoming Armani restaurant and ten Armani-designed apartments (all of which have sold), this "store" is a hybrid space spanning clothing, hospitality and residential.



Photographs Courtesy: GIORGIO ARMANI